COMPANY POLICY HANDBOOK

20-page sample document for PDF Question Answering and RAG testing

Document note

This is a fictional company handbook created for testing document loading, chunking, retrieval, answer generation, and page citations. It is not an actual company's policy and is not legal advice.

1. Company Overview and Working Principles

Purpose

This handbook describes the fictional company Northstar Solutions' workplace policies. It is designed as a sample document for testing PDF question-answering and retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) systems.

Core principles

Employees are expected to act with integrity, respect colleagues, protect confidential information, and make decisions using accurate information. Managers should apply policies consistently and explain exceptions in writing.

Scope

The policies apply to full-time employees, part-time employees, interns, and contractors when they are performing work for Northstar Solutions. Local law and signed employment agreements take precedence if they conflict with this sample handbook.

Company facts for retrieval tests

The company was founded in 2018. Its fictional headquarters is in Hyderabad, India. The standard work week is Monday through Friday. The People Operations team owns this handbook.

Review cycle

People Operations reviews the handbook every January. Employees receive notice when a material policy changes. Questions about interpretation should be sent to peopleops@northstar.example.

2. Working Hours and Attendance

Standard schedule

The standard schedule is 9:30 a.m. to 6:00 p.m., Monday through Friday, including a 30-minute lunch break. Some teams may use approved shift schedules.

Attendance records

Employees must record attendance through the company attendance portal. A missed punch should be corrected within two business days with the manager's approval.

Late arrival

An employee expecting to arrive more than 15 minutes late should notify the manager before the scheduled start time when practical. Repeated lateness may lead to a documented discussion.

Absence notification

For an unexpected absence, employees should notify their manager and People Operations as early as possible, preferably before 9:30 a.m.

Flexible schedules

A manager may approve a temporary schedule adjustment for personal or operational reasons. Approval should state the start date, end date, and revised hours.

3. Leave and Holidays

Annual leave

Eligible full-time employees receive 18 days of annual leave per calendar year. Leave is credited monthly at 1.5 days. Part-time and contract arrangements may differ according to their written terms.

Request procedure

Employees should submit annual leave requests through the HR portal at least five working days in advance for leave of up to three consecutive days, and ten working days in advance for longer leave.

Sick leave

Employees receive 10 days of sick leave per calendar year. A medical certificate may be requested for an absence of more than three consecutive working days, subject to applicable law.

Public holidays

The company publishes its holiday calendar each December for the following year. The calendar includes applicable national and regional holidays for each office.

Carryover

Up to five unused annual-leave days may be carried into the next calendar year and must be used by March 31. Unused sick leave is not carried over under this sample policy.

4. Remote and Hybrid Work

Eligibility

Remote or hybrid work depends on role requirements, information-security needs, performance, and manager approval. Customer-facing or equipment-dependent roles may require more on-site work.

Hybrid schedule

The default hybrid arrangement is up to two remote days per week. Team leaders may designate common office days for collaboration.

Remote workspace

Employees must use a private workspace where confidential conversations and documents cannot be casually viewed or overheard by unauthorized people.

Availability

Remote employees must remain reachable during their agreed working hours and attend scheduled meetings. Calendar status should accurately reflect availability.

Review and revocation

Managers review remote-work arrangements every quarter. An arrangement may be adjusted if business needs, security concerns, or performance issues require a change.

5. Code of Conduct and Professional Behavior

Respectful workplace

Employees must communicate respectfully and must not engage in harassment, bullying, threats, or discriminatory conduct.

Conflicts of interest

Employees must disclose outside activities, financial interests, or relationships that could influence—or appear to influence—business decisions. The Compliance team reviews disclosures.

Gifts and hospitality

Employees may accept a modest business meal valued at no more than INR 2,000 per person when it is infrequent and transparent. Cash gifts are prohibited. Gifts above the threshold require prior Compliance approval.

Company representation

Only authorized spokespersons may make public statements on behalf of the company. Employees should not imply that personal opinions represent company positions.

Reporting concerns

Concerns may be reported to a manager, People Operations, or Compliance. Retaliation against a person who raises a concern in good faith is prohibited.

6. Information Security

Account security

Employees must use unique passwords and multi-factor authentication (MFA) for company accounts wherever supported. Passwords must not be shared with colleagues.

Device security

Company devices must use approved endpoint protection, automatic screen locking, and supported operating-system updates. Lost or stolen devices must be reported to IT Security immediately.

Data handling

Company information must be stored only in approved services. Sensitive files must not be copied to personal email, personal cloud drives, or unapproved USB devices.

Incident reporting

Suspected phishing, malware, credential theft, or unauthorized access must be reported to security@northstar.example or the IT help desk as soon as possible.

Minimum access

Access permissions are granted according to job responsibilities. Managers must request removal of access when an employee changes roles or leaves the company.

7. Data Classification and Privacy

Public data

Public data is approved for unrestricted external release, such as published press releases and public website content.

Internal data

Internal data is intended for employees and approved contractors. It should be shared externally only with authorization.

Confidential data

Confidential data includes customer contracts, non-public financial information, employee records, and unreleased product plans. Access is limited to people with a business need.

Restricted data

Restricted data includes authentication secrets, highly sensitive personal information, and security incident evidence. It requires approved storage, strict access controls, and secure transfer methods.

Privacy principles

Collect only personal information needed for a defined purpose, restrict access, keep it only as long as required, and use approved procedures for correction or deletion requests.

8. Acceptable Use of Technology

Permitted use

Company technology is primarily for business activities. Limited personal use is allowed if it does not disrupt work, create security risk, or violate law or company policy.

Prohibited activities

Employees must not disable security controls, install unapproved software with elevated privileges, access another person's account, or use company systems for unlawful activity.

Software installation

Software must be obtained from approved sources and installed through IT-approved procedures. Open-source packages used in company projects must be reviewed under the software approval process.

Monitoring

The company may log and review use of its systems for security, compliance, troubleshooting, and legal obligations, subject to applicable law and published notices.

Return of equipment

Employees must return company equipment, access cards, and storage media when requested or when employment ends.

9. Email, Messaging, and Phishing

Message verification

Employees should verify unusual requests for money, gift cards, passwords, confidential files, or urgent account changes through a separate trusted channel.

Suspicious links

Do not enter credentials after following an unexpected link. Hover over links where supported, inspect the destination carefully, and use the company reporting function.

Attachments

Unexpected attachments, especially executable files or password-protected archives, should not be opened until their legitimacy is verified.

Reporting

Use the email client's Report Phishing function or forward the message as an attachment to security@northstar.example. Do not forward suspicious links to coworkers as a warning.

Response

IT Security may quarantine messages, reset credentials, block domains, or isolate devices while investigating a suspected incident.

10. Travel and Expense Reimbursement

Pre-approval

Business travel requires manager approval before booking. International travel also requires approval from the department head and confirmation of any applicable travel requirements.

Economy travel

Air travel under six hours should normally be booked in economy class. Exceptions require written approval from the department head.

Hotel limits

The standard hotel limit is INR 7,500 per night in Hyderabad and INR 10,000 per night in other major Indian metro cities, excluding taxes. Higher rates require advance approval.

Expense claims

Employees must submit expense claims within 15 calendar days after the trip and attach itemized receipts for individual expenses above INR 500.

Non-reimbursable items

Personal entertainment, traffic fines, minibar purchases, and expenses for non-business companions are not reimbursable unless a written exception is approved.

11. Recruitment and Onboarding

Hiring process

Hiring decisions should be based on role-related skills, experience, demonstrated capability, and business needs. Interviewers must use consistent criteria for candidates applying to the same role.

Interview records

Interview feedback should be entered into the recruitment system within two business days. Feedback should describe job-related evidence rather than personal assumptions.

Offer approval

A written employment offer may be issued only after the hiring manager and People Operations approve the role, compensation, and start date.

First week

New employees should complete identity and employment documentation, security training, policy acknowledgement, and required tool setup during their first week.

Probation

The standard probation period is six months unless the offer letter specifies a different period. The manager should provide a documented review before the probation period ends.

12. Learning and Performance Reviews

Review schedule

Formal performance reviews occur twice a year, in June and December. Managers should discuss outcomes, strengths, development areas, and goals.

Goal setting

Each employee should agree on three to five measurable goals with their manager at the beginning of each review cycle.

Learning budget

Eligible employees may request up to INR 20,000 per calendar year for approved courses, certifications, or conferences related to their role.

Approval and evidence

Learning expenses require manager approval before purchase. Employees must provide proof of completion or attendance when available.

Development plans

When a skill gap is identified, the manager and employee should document specific actions, support needed, and a target review date.

13. Compensation, Payroll, and Benefits

Payroll date

Monthly salary is normally paid on the last working day of each month. If that day is a bank holiday, payment is generally made on the preceding working day.

Payroll questions

Employees should report suspected payroll errors to payroll@northstar.example within five business days of receiving the payslip.

Salary confidentiality

Employees should handle payroll records and other employees' compensation data as confidential information. Authorized personnel may access such data for legitimate duties.

Benefits enrollment

New employees should complete benefits enrollment within 30 calendar days of their start date, subject to plan eligibility and provider rules.

Deductions

Taxes and other lawful deductions are processed according to applicable requirements and the employee's authorized selections.

14. Workplace Health, Safety, and Wellbeing

Emergency response

Employees must follow posted evacuation instructions and report hazards to Facilities. Emergency exits and fire equipment must never be blocked.

Accidents

Any workplace injury, near miss, or unsafe condition should be reported to Facilities and the employee's manager promptly, even when no immediate medical treatment is needed.

Ergonomics

Employees should adjust chairs, monitors, and keyboards to maintain a comfortable working posture and take brief movement breaks during extended screen work.

Wellbeing support

Employees may contact People Operations for information about available wellbeing resources and support options.

Visitors

Visitors must register at reception, wear the required visitor badge, and remain with an authorized host in restricted areas.

15. Procurement and Vendor Management

Purchase requests

Employees must submit a purchase request before committing company funds. Requests should include business purpose, estimated cost, vendor details, and budget owner.

Competitive quotes

Purchases above INR 100,000 require at least three comparable written quotations unless Procurement approves a documented exception.

Vendor due diligence

New vendors may be reviewed for security, privacy, financial, legal, and operational risks before access or purchase approval.

Contract signing

Only employees with delegated signing authority may sign vendor agreements. A purchase order does not replace a required signed contract.

Invoice handling

Invoices must match approved purchase orders and evidence of delivery. Discrepancies should be resolved before payment.

16. Customer Information and Support

Identity verification

Support personnel must verify a customer's identity using the approved process before discussing account-specific or confidential information.

Ticket response

The standard initial response target is one business day for normal-priority tickets and one hour for high-priority service outages.

Escalation

A ticket should be escalated to the technical lead when it remains unresolved for more than two business days or presents a security or privacy risk.

Customer data

Customer information must be accessed only for the support task and must not be downloaded to personal devices or retained in unapproved notes.

Communication

Support updates should describe known facts, the next action, and the expected time of the next update. Employees must not promise an unconfirmed resolution time.

17. Business Continuity and Incident Management

Incident levels

Severity 1 means a critical service outage or confirmed major data exposure. Severity 2 means substantial service degradation. Severity 3 means limited impact with a reasonable workaround.

Notification target

The incident coordinator should acknowledge a Severity 1 report within 15 minutes and notify the incident response group immediately.

Roles

The incident coordinator manages the response, the technical lead investigates the cause, Communications prepares approved updates, and the business owner assesses customer impact.

Recovery

Recovery steps must prioritize safety, data integrity, and restoration of critical services. Changes made during an incident should be documented.

Post-incident review

For Severity 1 and Severity 2 incidents, the team should complete a blameless review within five business days after service restoration.

18. Records Retention and Document Management

Approved repositories

Business records must be stored in approved document management systems with suitable access permissions and backup coverage.

Retention schedule

Routine project records should normally be retained for three years after project closure. Financial records should be retained for seven years unless law or an approved schedule requires otherwise.

Legal holds

When Legal issues a preservation notice, employees must not delete or alter records covered by that notice until the hold is formally released.

Version control

Documents that guide business decisions should identify an owner, a version, and a review date. Superseded versions should be archived when required for audit purposes.

Secure disposal

Confidential paper records must be placed in secure shredding bins. Digital records must be deleted using approved procedures when retention requirements end.

19. Ethics, Complaints, and Disciplinary Process

Good-faith reporting

Employees may report suspected misconduct to their manager, Compliance, or People Operations. Reports may include supporting details, dates, and relevant records.

Confidential handling

Reports are shared only with people who need the information to assess or investigate the concern, subject to legal requirements.

Investigation

The company will assess the concern, determine appropriate next steps, and seek relevant information from involved parties. Employees are expected to cooperate honestly.

Non-retaliation

Threatening, disadvantaging, or harassing someone because they made a good-faith report or participated in an investigation is prohibited.

Corrective action

Depending on the findings and severity, corrective action may include coaching, training, a written warning, access restrictions, or termination, consistent with applicable law.

20. Separation, Exit, and Handbook Questions

Notice and transition

Employees should follow the notice period in their employment agreement and work with their manager on a transition plan, subject to applicable law.

Exit checklist

Before the final working day, employees must return company property, transfer business records, resolve outstanding expenses, and identify the status of open work.

Access removal

IT should disable or adjust system access according to the approved departure plan. Access may be removed earlier when security or legal considerations require it.

Final settlement

Final salary and eligible reimbursements are processed according to applicable law, company procedures, and the employee's contractual terms.

Handbook ownership

People Operations owns this sample handbook. Questions should be sent to peopleops@northstar.example. This fictional handbook is for software testing and is not legal advice or an actual company's official policy.